Rebecca of Sunnybrook Farm

A simplified retelling

Original story by Kate Douglas Wiggin

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. The unexpected niece

Rebecca Rowena Randall travelled from her family’s farm to live with two aunts in the village of Riverboro. Her mother had several children and very little money. The aunts had offered to take one girl and help with her education.

They had expected Rebecca’s older, more practical sister Hannah. Instead, Rebecca arrived with a lively imagination, dark eyes and plenty to say.

Aunt Miranda was strict. She valued neatness, sensible work and respect for established rules. Aunt Jane was gentler and more ready to see the frightened child behind Rebecca’s conversation.

Rebecca missed her mother and the other children, but she was also curious about everything. On the journey, she had talked freely with the driver, Mr Jeremiah Cobb. He and his wife soon became friends she could turn to when the brick house felt too severe.

Living with the aunts offered an opportunity. It also meant learning that affection was not always expressed in a language she immediately understood.

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2. A different kind of order

Rebecca tried to meet Miranda’s expectations, but her mind moved quickly towards stories, poems and people. An object that needed dusting could suggest a character; a journey on an errand could become an adventure.

Miranda saw distraction where Rebecca felt possibility. Corrections were frequent. Rebecca sometimes cried, sometimes rebelled inwardly and sometimes found the criticism justified.

At school, her quick understanding and gift for words began to matter. She made a close friend in Emma Jane Perkins. Emma Jane was quieter, but her loyalty gave Rebecca a place where she did not always have to explain herself.

Rebecca enjoyed performing and writing. Teachers could see ability beneath her uneven habits. Success, however, did not remove the need to work carefully. She had to discover how to use her imagination without allowing it to carry her away from every practical task.

Her aunts, too, had something to learn. The child they

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had not expected could not become Hannah simply by being corrected often enough.

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3. Soap and a new acquaintance

Rebecca and Emma Jane became involved in selling soap to help a struggling family obtain a useful prize. The undertaking took them beyond the familiar boundaries of school and home.

At one house, they met Adam Ladd, a successful businessman. Rebecca’s earnest speech and inventive manner amused him. He bought generously and became interested in her future.

Rebecca thought of him as “Mr Aladdin,” connecting his name with the wonderful possibilities of a story she knew. He was not a magical rescuer, but he recognised a mind that deserved an opportunity.

Their friendship developed through occasional meetings and correspondence. He encouraged her education and followed her progress. To Rebecca, an adult’s interest could be powerful when it did not begin by listing everything she had done wrong.

She still had to face Miranda’s judgement when an adventure crossed the rules at home. Being admired elsewhere did not automatically make the household

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easier to understand.

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4. The things words can do

Rebecca’s talent found room in school exercises, performances and celebrations. Writing allowed her to give shape to feelings she could not always express in an ordinary argument.

She also became interested in the different lives around her. Some people had money but little warmth; others struggled financially and still made room for kindness. The village was more complicated than a division between important adults and children who must obey them.

Occasionally, her enthusiasm produced embarrassment. She might speak too soon, trust an exciting idea too readily or imagine that an occasion would unfold exactly as she wished.

Experience helped her become more thoughtful without making her silent. Emma Jane’s steady friendship and Aunt Jane’s sympathy supported that change.

Miranda remained difficult to please, yet Rebecca gradually understood the fears and habits behind her severity. Understanding did not make every criticism

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fair, but it made her aunt a person rather than simply an obstacle.

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5. A wider education

Rebecca went on to study at Wareham. The new school brought more demanding lessons, broader friendships and the chance to imagine work she might do as an adult.

She applied herself and earned recognition for her abilities. She could now see that talent became more useful when joined to discipline. A poem that arrived easily still needed revision; a promising student still needed to learn.

At home, her mother continued to manage hardship and the needs of the younger children. Rebecca wanted success partly because she hoped to help them. Education was not simply an escape from her family. It might give her a way to support them more effectively.

Adam Ladd remained interested in her progress. His admiration grew as she matured, but Rebecca’s immediate future centred on study, family and the choices opening before her.

The girl who had arrived at Riverboro feeling like the wrong niece was beginning to discover a place that

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depended on her own gifts.

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6. Returning to the brick house

During these years, illness and age changed life at her aunts’ home. Miranda’s health declined. Rebecca returned and helped care for her.

The work was not glamorous. It required patience, attention and the willingness to remain when there was no audience to praise a clever performance. Rebecca brought affection into a household where it had often been hidden behind rules.

Miranda came to understand her niece more fully. The qualities she had treated as troublesome were not simply faults. Rebecca’s warmth and imagination had become part of what the house needed.

After Miranda died, Rebecca learned that her aunt had left her the brick house. The inheritance offered security for a future that had previously depended on uncertain earnings and other people’s generosity.

It did not decide every part of her life. She still had work to choose and a family to care about. But the house that had first made her feel like an outsider had become a place she could call her own.

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Rebecca looked ahead with the imagination that had always belonged to her, now joined by experience and a clearer sense of responsibility.

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Words to keep

Practical — concerned with doing useful things effectively. Hannah was considered the more practical sister.

Severity — strictness that can seem harsh. Miranda’s severity frightened Rebecca.

Correspondence — communication through letters. Rebecca kept in touch through correspondence.

Discipline — regular effort and control directed towards a goal. Her writing benefited from discipline.

Inheritance — property or money left after a death. The house became Rebecca’s inheritance.

Opportunity — a chance to do or develop something. Education gave her an opportunity to help her family.

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A question to carry with you

How can an adult guide an imaginative child without treating imagination itself as a problem to remove?

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